



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical Schools of Douglas County
School Website: <https://dc.ascentcolorado.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ascent Colorado Classical Schools – Douglas County (CD: 80124) demonstrates a robust classical-education orientation across all six rubric categories. Public-facing materials consistently foreground the liberal-arts core: a content-rich, Western-civilization-centered curriculum that integrates literature, history, philosophy, languages (notably Latin), and the arts; explicit emphasis on virtue and character formation; teacher-led instruction with traditional methods; and a clear partnership with families and communities to sustain a classical ethos. The school anchors its mission in forming minds and hearts toward truth, goodness, and beauty, and it operationalizes this through hallmarks like a Core Knowledge-based K–8 sequence, high regard for great books and original sources, and a governance commitment to Western-tradition pedagogy. Communal practices (opening ceremonies, Scholé-inspired rhythms, Constitution Day, pledges) and structures (House System; parent partnerships; Core Virtues) reinforce a liturgical-style cadence and shared tradition. The aggregate assessment across all categories is CLASSICAL.

Evidence for this conclusion is drawn from the school's public-facing materials and policy documents, including explicit statements about truth/goodness/beauty, the Western-civilization focus, the liberal-arts Trivium/Quadrivium framework, Latin study, great books/common texts, and a pedagogy that combines Socratic elements with traditional teacher-led instruction, plus a strong emphasis on parental involvement and a civically virtuous culture. See sources describing hallmarks of classical education, the motto and mission emphasis, curriculum highlights (Core Knowledge, Latin, Western civilization, great books), and parental/community commitments. Citations include: hallmarks emphasizing truth/beauty/virtue and Western tradition; explicit mission statements and pledges; Latin and Great Books/Western-civilization programs; Core Virtues and parental partnership policies. See the following representative materials: hallmarks of classical education with truth/goodness/beauty emphasis; motto and mission statements; Latin and Great Books emphasis; Core Knowledge curriculum; and Parent Partnership policies.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a classical, virtue-centered frame and leans on the transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) as guiding ideals in education, aligned with liberal-arts formation and Western tradition. The school's stated hallmarks include "Teaching objective standards of truth, beauty, and virtue" and a mission framed by moral and civic virtue within a Western-civilization context.

- The school explicitly situates education within a tradition of Western civilization and great books, with a pledge whose language centers on the True, the Good, and the Beautiful, reinforcing a formation-oriented, transcendently oriented aim.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present on public materials: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; great books; Western civilization; Logos (referenced in contextual policy discussions); contemplation/wonder (Scholé-linked language and virtue formation appear in materials about curriculum and mission). The explicit motto and mission statements center the school on truth, virtue, and beauty as enduring goods. - Negative keywords: not evidenced in public materials (no explicit signals of relativism,

secularism, or value-neutral ethics). The lexicon materials describe potential negative signals, but the school materials themselves do not demonstrate them.

Why this rating - The public materials foreground the transcendental aims (truth/goodness/beauty), virtue formation, and a liturgical cadence of communal learning grounded in the Western tradition. While not a theologically explicit church school, the alignment with classical-education axioms is strong and coherent with the Positive Keyword indicators in the Six Essential Elements framework. Therefore CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements emphasize forming virtuous, wise persons rather than just job preparation; “formation” and “virtue” are central, with explicit aims around liberal arts, moral character, and civic virtue; focus on human flourishing and the common good rather than merely career outcomes. The policy/mission materials elevate paideia-like aims and the pursuit of the true/good/beautiful. - The school’s stated motto and narrative about pursuing “the True, the Good, and the Beautiful,” plus the emphasis on wonder and moral imagination, align with a formation-oriented telos rather than purely utilitarian aims.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, teleology/paideia, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, Great Conversation, formation of character, moral imagination. - Negative keywords: absent in public materials (no explicit signaling of work-preparation emphasis or 21st-century-skills/college-career primacy in the public-facing mission). The policy materials emphasize classical formation over purely vocational aims.

Why this rating - Public materials clearly present formation-centered aims and a classical telos (virtue, wisdom, and humane excellence). The absence of a dominant “career-readiness” frame in the public-facing mission supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented with a Core Knowledge sequence (K–8) and a humanities emphasis in upper grades; Latin instruction is highlighted; a strong emphasis on great works, primary sources, and Western civilization; explicit attention to grammar, logic, and rhetoric; and a goal of cultivating a sense of wonder. Core Knowledge and explicit literacy (Riggs phonics) are foregrounded, and Latin is positioned as a central component of a Western-civilization education.

- Public materials describe the Great Books/Western-civilization approach, primary sources, and a curriculum designed to preserve and transmit the Western intellectual heritage. The inclusion of Latin and a literature-centric progression (Greece & Rome, Western Civilization sequences) reinforces the Great-Books/Great-Conversation orientation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; primary sources; Latin; Western civilization; history integrated with literature; continuity of Western canon; sacred/tradition-related phrasing tied to classical pedagogy. - Negative keywords: not evidenced (the materials emphasize a classical, content-rich curriculum rather than a purely modern, project-based, STEM-first approach). Negative signals from the lexicon (e.g., “STEM-first framing” or “project-based dominance”) are not reflected in the public curriculum materials.

Why this rating - The program is explicitly built around liberal-arts foundations, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Latin, and Western civilization—core elements of classical curriculum logic. Public materials consistently reflect these priorities, justifying CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize teacher-led, traditional instruction aligned with a content-rich curriculum, and explicitly mention increased use of Socratic techniques as students progress (especially in

higher grades). There is also explicit mention of memory-focused recitation/memorization (as part of classical pedagogy) and the practice of Socratic discussion in upper grades. Scholé-inspired rhythms (restful learning) are also described. - The school's model includes a robust emphasis on classic pedagogy, including direct instruction with Socratic elements, memorization/recitation, and a living-curriculum approach, all consistent with classical pedagogy. - Communal and ritual practices (Constitution Day, Scholé-oriented celebrations, a House System) contribute to a disciplined, tradition-based classroom culture that supports classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, dialectic, great conversation, memorization/recitation, chanting, shadowing opportunities for public speaking, memorizations as core memory work, Scholé, restfulness, teacher-led instruction, classic rhetoric, and structured discussion. - Negative keywords: not evidenced in public materials (no primary emphasis on purely student-centered, project-based, or constructivist pedagogy dominating classroom practice). The materials emphasize classical methods over student-led-only approaches.

Why this rating - The pedagogy is clearly anchored in traditional/classical methods (teacher-led, Socratic inquiry, memorization/recitation, classical rhetoric development), reinforced by Scholé-inspired rhythm. This aligns with CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials foreground teachers as the “living curriculum,” masters/mentors who model virtue and expertise; the school emphasizes a faculty culture of collaboration, shared mission, and high expectations. The “Guardians” House System articulates teacher-student mentorship and a shared culture around virtue and excellence. - The policy materials discuss high standards for teacher qualifications, accountability to the headmaster, and a culture of decorum and studiousness. The hallmarks emphasize a faculty that conveys real knowledge through traditional methods.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; masters/mentors; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture; teacher-led, high-quality instruction; moral exemplars; lifelong learning for faculty; master-teacher model. - Negative keywords: not evidenced (no strong signals of a purely administrative or non-mentoring faculty culture). The public materials depict a faculty engaged in traditional, mentor-like roles.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently portray faculty as central to classical formation, with teacher-led instruction, traditional pedagogy, and a lived-ethos model that aligns with the classical ideal of the “living curriculum.” This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly prioritizes parent partnerships (“Parents and guardians are the primary educators of students”) and commits to transparency, curriculum review, and parent involvement; it positions parents as co-educators in the classical project and offers opportunities for families to engage via book studies and community gatherings. The policy language stresses parental authority and active involvement. - The school publishes a policy framework that emphasizes parental partnership, home-school alignment, and a culture of family involvement, with opportunities for family engagement in the classical project. - The school's community materials (House System, shared rituals) foster a culture of hospitality and parent participation, including campus visits and public-facing communications to engage families.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parents as co-teachers; household formation; family involvement; living tradition in the family; parental formation; open campus; parent book clubs/gatherings. - Negative keywords: not evidenced (no “customer” framing; no minimal-parent-involvement signals). The materials emphasize ongoing parent-partnership and engagement.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently emphasize parent partnership as central to classical education, with explicit calls for parental involvement and transparency. This aligns with CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

No category is classified as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; all six categories fall squarely in CLASSICAL. Therefore, there are no category-specific needle-moving actions required to reach CLASSICAL alignment. If desired, future refinements could further codify and publicly showcase explicit theology/theological integration (where appropriate for a public charter) and broaden visible liturgical-cultural practices separate from secular, civic-virtue rituals, but the current materials already reflect a coherent classical trajectory. No mandatory needle-moving changes are identified based on the rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.